

Overview

This guide will help you set up an APA Style student paper. The basic setup directions apply to the entire paper. The following sections illustrate how to set up the major sections of a student paper: the title page, the text, tables and figures, and the reference list.

Basic Setup

Seventh edition APA Style was designed with modern word-processing programs in mind. Most default settings in programs such as Academic Writer, Microsoft Word, and Google Docs already comply with APA Style. However, you may need to make a few adjustments before you begin writing.

- **Margins:** Use 1-inch margins on all sides of the page (top, bottom, left, and right).
- **Font:** Use a legible font. Many fonts are acceptable, including 11-point Calibri, 11-point Arial, 12-point Times New Roman, and 11-point Georgia. The default font of your word-processing program is acceptable.
- **Line spacing:** Use double-spacing for the entire paper (including block quotations and the reference list). Do not add blank lines before or after headings. Do not add extra spacing between paragraphs.
- **Paragraph alignment and indentation:** Align paragraphs of text to the left margin. Leave the right margin ragged. Do not use full justification. Indent the first line of every paragraph of text 0.5 inches, using the tab key or the paragraph-formatting function of your word-processing program.
- **Page numbers:** Put a page number in the top right corner of every page, including the title page or cover page, which is page 1. Student papers do not require a running head on any page.

Title Page Setup

Title Page Elements

The student paper title page includes the following elements, centered on the page:

1. **Page number** — Page number 1 appears in the top right corner of the page in the page header.
2. **Paper title** — The paper's title should be centered, bold, and written in title case. It should be three or four lines below the top margin of the page.
3. **Author names** — Authors' names appear one double-spaced line below the title. They should be written as: First name, middle initial(s), last name. Omit all professional titles and/or degrees (e.g., Dr., Rev., PhD, MA).
4. **Affiliation** — The affiliation consists of the department of the course and the name of the university.
5. **Course number and name** — Write the course number and name and instructor name as shown on course materials.
6. **Instructor name** — The instructor's name appears below the course information.
7. **Due date** — Use the date format used in your country for the assignment due date.

! No Running Head for Student Papers

No running heads are required for student papers. Student papers in APA also do not require author notes, abstracts, or keywords, which would normally fall at the bottom of the title page and on the next page afterwards. Your instructor may ask for them anyway — see the APA professional sample paper for guidelines for those.

Title Page Formatting

- **Double-space** the whole title page.
- Place the title **three or four lines down** from the top margin of the page.
- Leave an **extra line between the title and author names**.
- **Center** the entire title page (except the page number).
- The paper title should be **bold**.
- All other title page elements should be in standard font (no bold, no italic).

Text Setup

Text Elements

- Repeat the paper title at the top of the first page of text (centered, bold).
- Begin with an introduction to provide background and context.
- Use descriptive headings to identify other sections (e.g., Method, Results, Discussion for quantitative research papers).
- Sections and headings vary depending on paper type and complexity.
- Text can include tables and figures, block quotations, headings, and footnotes.

Text Formatting

- **Text Font:** Use the same font throughout the entire paper. Write body text in standard (nonbold, nonitalic) font. Use italics sparingly, for instance to highlight a key term on first use.
- **Text Line Spacing:** Double-space all text, including headings and section labels, paragraphs of text, and block quotes.
- **Text Alignment:** Center the paper title at the top of the first page. Left-align all body text. Leave the right margin ragged. Indent the first line of paragraphs 0.5 inches.
- **Block Quotation Alignment:** Indent the whole block quote 0.5 inches from the left margin (also double-spaced).

Headings Format

APA Style uses five levels of headings. Most student papers only use the first three levels.

Table 1: APA 7th edition heading levels and their formatting.

Level	Format
1	Centered, Bold, Title Case Heading Text begins as a new paragraph.
2	Flush Left, Bold, Title Case Heading Text begins as a new paragraph.
3	<i>Flush Left, Bold Italic, Title Case Heading</i> Text begins as a new paragraph.
4	<i>**Indented, Bold, Title Case Heading, Ending With**</i> a Period. Text begins on the same line and continues as a regular paragraph.
5	<i>***Indented, Bold Italic, Title Case Heading, Ending***</i> <i>With a Period.</i> Text begins on the same line and continues as a regular paragraph.

- **Alignment:** Center Level 1 headings. Left-align Level 2 and Level 3 headings. Indent Level 4 and Level 5 headings like a paragraph.
- **Font:** Boldface all headings. Also italicize Level 3 and Level 5 headings.

Tip

Create heading styles using your word-processing program (built into Academic Writer, available for Word via [sample papers](#) on the APA Style website).

Tables and Figures Setup

Only some papers have tables and figures. Tables and figures share the same elements.

Table Elements

Each table includes the following components:

1. **Number** — Tables are numbered sequentially (Table 1, Table 2, etc.) in bold.
2. **Title** — A brief, descriptive title in italics, placed on the line below the table number.
3. **Body** — The table body contains the rows and columns of data.
4. **Note** (optional) — A general note explaining abbreviations or providing additional context, beginning with “*Note.*” in italics.

Figure Elements

Each figure includes the following components:

1. **Number** — Figures are numbered sequentially (Figure 1, Figure 2, etc.) in bold.
2. **Title** — A brief, descriptive title in italics, placed on the line below the figure number.
3. **Image** — The figure image itself.
4. **Note** (optional) — A general note explaining the figure, beginning with “*Note.*” in italics.

Table and Figure Line Spacing

- Double-space the number and title for both tables and figures.
- Table body may use single-, 1.5-, or double-spacing (adjust as needed for readability).
- Double-space any notes below the table or figure.
- Default settings for spacing in images should be adjusted as needed for readability.

Reference List Setup

Reference List Elements

- The reference list begins on a new page after the text.
- “**References**” is centered and bold at the top of the page.
- All references are double-spaced.
- References use a **hanging indent** — the first line is flush left; subsequent lines are indented 0.5 inches.

Reference List Format and Order

- Alphabetize references by the first author’s last name.
- For works with no author, alphabetize by title.
- Capitalize only the first word of the title, the first word after a colon, and proper nouns for article and book titles.
- Italicize titles of longer works (books, journals).
- Include the DOI or URL when available.

i Note

For more comprehensive information on APA Style, visit the [APA Style website](#) or consult the *Publication Manual of the American Psychological Association* (7th ed.).